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Spinoza and the Reciprocity of Nature

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Abstract
This paper develops an account of the reciprocity of Nature in Spinoza as a central yet underappreciated dimension of Spinoza's relational metaphysics. Building on Ziporyn's interpretation of Spinoza, the paper argues that any understanding of infinity and necessity is incomplete without Spinoza's relational account of the reciprocity of God or Nature (*Deus sive Natura*). Through a close analysis of the *Ethics*, the *Principles* and *Letter 32*, the paper shows that for Spinoza all finite things are reciprocally determined by another singular thing to exist in a certain way through the infinite, eternal and equal force [*vis*] of Nature by which each thing perseveres in existing. This reciprocal and omnipresent structure of the whole of Nature constitutes the engaged, phenomenological experience of Individuality: God or Nature does not respond purposively or personally, yet every movement and thought is necessarily met by reciprocal determinations within the immediacy of Nature itself. The paper concludes that Ziporyn's account is strengthened by a relational metaphysics grounded not in intellectual contemplation of infinite Substance but rather in the active and embodied immersion in the infinite encounters of Nature's reciprocity.

Keywords Spinoza · Religion · Mystical atheism · Reciprocity · Immanence · Infinity · Brook Ziporyn

1 Introduction

In "Die Religion Spinoza", Carl Gebhardt documented the wide-ranging religious influences upon Spinoza's metaphysical thought, concluding that Spinoza's "religious metaphysics" should be characterized as a *Vernunftreligion* – a religion of Reason (Gebhardt 1933: 341) By this, Gebhardt summarized what some have called Spinoza's "relational metaphysics" grounded not in a transcendent, purposeful God but in common *ratios* by which all finite things move, relate, agree and cohere as expressions of the immanent and eternal power of Nature (Costa 2025; Sangiacomo 2019; Sharp 2011; Armstrong et al. 2019; Sacksteder 1977; Kisner 2011; Buhr 2023; Mason 1997; Fraenkel 2014; Buijs 2021; Carlisle 2021; Ziporyn 2024). These accounts complement mystical interpretations of Spinoza, arguing that a Spinozist subject grasping the world through intuition *(scientia intuitiva*) feels and experiences that they are existentially engaged in the world as a singular and eternal essence (Wetlesen 1977: 481).[1] In this vein, recent scholarship on Spinoza and religion has re-examined Spinoza's relational conception of God or Nature as kind of unique philosophical religion.[2] Jonathan Israel, as one example,

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[1] There is considerable debate in this literature over what form of knowledge is necessary for a "mystical" experience in Spinoza. For Spinoza, there are three forms of knowledge: imagination (*imaginatio*), Reason (*ratio*) and intuition (*scientia intuitiva*). The debate here centers on whether "mystical" union with the eternal and infinite Substance of Nature is achieved only through intuition, or whether it may also be achieved through *ratio*. I simply note here that Spinoza clearly states in E4p62dem that reason (*ratio*) conceives things under the aspect of eternity and necessity: "Whatever the Mind conceives under the guidance of reason, it conceives under the same species of eternity, or necessity (by IIP44C2) and is affected with the same certainty" (E4p62dem). See also E4p36s.

[2] See Richard Mason, *The God of Spinoza: a philosophical study*. (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997); Carlos Fraenkel, *Philosophical Religions from Plato to Spinoza: Reason, Religion, and Autonomy* (Cambridge University Press: Cambridge, 2014); Martijn Buijs, "Spinoza and the Possibility of a Philosophical Religion." *Philosophies (Basel)* 6 (2). (2021) MDPI AG: 34. doi:https://doi.org/10.3390/philosophies6020034; Claire Carlisle, *Spinoza's religion: a new reading of the Ethics*. (Princeton University Press, Princeton, 2021); Brook Ziporyn, *Experiments in mystical atheism: godless epiphanies from Daoism to Spinoza and beyond.* (University of Chicago Press, Chicago, 2024).

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has followed Gebhardt's study by reexamining Spinoza's relationship to the Collegiants in the seventeenth century Dutch Republic, a sectarian mystic movement founded in Rijnsburg who advanced a "Rational Religion".[3] However, while recent scholars have conducted studies comparing Spinoza's relational account of God with Hindu[4] and Jewish Kabbalah[5] influences, many scholars have long argued that Spinoza's unique conception of God cannot be reduced to one single belief system of Buddhism, Hinduism, atheism, mysticism, Christianity, or Jewish philosophy. Here, Mason (1997), Fraenkel (2014), Carlisle (2021) and Ziporyn (2024) are recent examples advancing the view that, despite Spinoza's deconstruction of the notions of a transcendent, providential God and divine teleology, Spinoza can be seen nonetheless as the founder of a unique philosophical-religious worldview grounded not in a transcendent deity but in what Spinoza calls "common notions" of reason (*ratio*). To demonstrate this, commentators have emphasized key philosophical notions in Spinoza's work, including the concepts of infinity (Ziporyn 2024: 211–237) eternity (Carlisle 2015; Melamed 2016: 129–167), *beatitudo* (Douglas 2024), *acquiescentia* (Carlisle 2021: 112–133; Laurens 2025), and more.

When we examine Spinoza's physics, commentators have long noted the "relational" element of his account of individuation of finite things understood through relational ratios of motion.[6] Here, Spinoza's account of the Attribute of Extension departs from Cartesian substance metaphysics by treating bodies not as self-subsisting corporeal entities but as patterns, "relations" or ratios of motion and rest within an infinite field of extension.[7] Garrett (2018) has observed that for Spinoza the individuation of all finite things consists in the preservation of stable ratios of motion and rest common to all individual bodies (2018). Under Curley's influential interpretation, Motion and Rest are understood as an infinite mode of Extension where motion-and-rest "are facts described by general, nomological propositions—necessary propositions which are always and everywhere valid. Their infinitude and eternity is a function of their strict universality." (Curley 1988: 61) For Curley, laws of motion (i.e. inertia, reciprocal force, etc.) may be deduced from common notions, such that the immediate infinite mode of Motion will simply refer to that set of general facts which are described by the laws of motion (Curley 1988: 61). Adler (1996) has added to this picture, arguing Spinoza's physics of Motion as the infinite mode of Extension must be understood as a systematic attempt to reconceive bodies as ratios or patterns of relations, rather than as independently individuated substances. (Adler 1996: 260–265)

Spinoza's physics of motion and individuation has led some commentators to liken Spinoza's account to contemporary quantum physics and perturbation theory (Rice 1996; Bennett 1984). Here, Rice concurs with Bennett that Spinoza's notion of infinite Extension anticipates field theory in contemporary physics, where Extension is conceived as space itself, and bodies in space are understood as perturbations of a force field wherein the position of a particle is represented by a wave function.[8] In this quantum interpretation of Spinoza's relational metaphysics, then, every finite thing

[3] See Jonathan Israel, 'Collegiants, Millenarians, and Quakers: The Mid- and Late 1650s', in *Spinoza, Life and Legacy* (Oxford, 2023; online edn, Oxford Academic, 20 July 2023). https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780198857488.003.0009, accessed 28 Jan. 2026.

[4] For an interesting comparative study advocating a *possible* Hindu influence on Spinoza, see Carlisle, Clare. 2025. "Spinoza and India: The Question of Influence." *British Journal for the History of Philosophy*, October, 1–23. doi:https://doi.org/10.1080/09608788.2025.2553310; Forslund, Noah. 2018. "Spinoza the Hindu: Advaita Interpretations of The Ethics". *Dianoia: The Undergraduate Philosophy Journal of Boston College*, no. V (May). https://doi.org/10.6017/dupjbc.v0iV.10461;

[5] For debates about the disputed extent of Kabbalistic influences on Spinoza's thought, see Jacques J. Rozenberg, "Spinoza and Kabbalah: convergences, divergences, and their theoretical implications." *Journal of Religion and Theology* 6, 1 (2024):59–80; Johan Aanen, "The Kabbalistic Sources of Spinoza", *The Journal of Jewish Thought and Philosophy* 24, 2 (2016): 279–299, doi: https://doi.org/10.1163/1477285X-02401003; Melamed, Yitzhak Y, 'From the *Gate of Heaven* to the 'Field of Holy Apples': Spinoza and the Kabbalah', *Spinoza's Labyrinths: Essays on His Metaphysics* (New York, NY, 2026; online edn, Oxford Academic, 5 Dec. 2025), https://doi.org/10.1093/9780197660164.003.0020, accessed 28 Mar. 2026.

[6] For interpretations of Motion and Rest as the immediate infinite mode of Extension, see Edwin Curley, "Spinoza's Metaphysics," in *The Cambridge Companion to Spinoza*, ed. Don Garrett (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996), 315–337; Tad Schmaltz, "Spinoza's Mediate Infinite Mode," *Journal of the History of Philosophy* 35, no. 2 (1997): 199–235; Kristin Primus (2019) "Spinoza's 'Infinite Modes' Reconsidered", *Journal of Modern Philosophy* 1: 11.

[7] On Spinoza's physical theory, see Jacob Adler, "Spinoza's Physical Philosophy," *Archiv für Geschichte der Philosophie* 78, no. 3 (1996): 253–276; Jonathan Bennett, *A Study of Spinoza's "Ethics"* (Indianapolis: Hackett, 1984); Lee C. Rice, "Spinoza's Infinite Extension." *History of European Ideas* (1996) 22 (1): 33–43. doi:https://doi.org/10.1016/0191-6599(94)00071-9; Don Garrett, *Nature and Necessity in Spinoza's Philosophy* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2018); John Carriero, *Between Two Worlds: A Reading of Descartes's Meditations* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2009), ch. 8.

[8] See Eric Schliesser, 'Spinoza and the Philosophy of Science: Mathematics, Motion, and Being', in Michael Della Rocca (ed.), *The Oxford Handbook of Spinoza*, Oxford Handbooks ((2017) ; online edn, Oxford Academic, 5 Sept. 2013), https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780195335828.013.020, accessed 30 Mar. 2026.). Schliesser argues that for Spinoza, physical knowledge of bodies in time and place is always inadequate and fallible. This is not necessarily incompatible with contemporary quantum physics, where the position of particles is probabilistic and represented by a wave function. On this reading, Spinoza may consistently be understood as allowing adequate knowledge that a body possesses the kinetic property of relative motion within a field, while denying adequate knowledge of its precise position at a determinate time and place; cf. *E*2p38–40.

is necessarily related insofar as each finite thing can only be understood within a quantum field of wave functions.

In this regard, scholars have observed that Spinoza's relational metaphysics is inseparable from his epistemology and moral psychology, particularly through his account of the second kind of knowledge, *ratio* or Reason (Curley 1988: 59–61; Sangiacomo 2019: ch. 4; Adler 1996; Soyarslan 2013; Lord 2018: 61–80; Yenter 2018; Bella 2023). Following Curley's argument that laws of motion can be deduced from the infinite mode of Motion and Rest through common notions (Curley 1988: 61), commentators have pointed to the crucial role of *ratio* in the discovery of these "common notions." According to Sangiacomo, common notions as defined in *E*2p38–40 are expressions of the ratio of agreement in nature between individuals as parts within the whole of Nature. Adler (1996) similarly emphasizes that Spinoza's physics is inseparable from his epistemology, since adequate knowledge of bodies depends on grasping the common structures that make their persistence intelligible. Lord interprets *ratio* as the epistemic expression of relational equality among things, insofar as adequate knowledge apprehends what is genuinely common. Cerezo Galán emphasizes that democratic citizenship, for Spinoza, depends on cultivating rational agreement rather than suppressing difference. Hasana Sharp (2011) has given an interpretation of Spinoza's "relational ontology" as a politics of re-naturalization where all individuals are co-constituted by interaction with others in a continuous process of change and mutual co-determination. Sangiacomo has emphasized how the discovery of common notions through Reason secures agreement in Spinoza's moral psychology and theory of affects as well as in his political theory and account of civic agreement and concord (James 2018: 61–77; Cerezo Galán 2016; Sharp 2011; Sangiacomo 2024; Sangiacomo 2019). These interpretations converge on the idea that Reason (*ratio*) provides adequate ideas common to all, which in turn facilitates social harmony and concord: to know through *ratio* is to recognize the common notions that bind individuals together in agreement as parts within the whole of Nature. On this picture, Spinoza's ethics and politics is necessarily relational because increasing our power necessarily entails joining in agreement with others in a common *ratio* of living (*rationem communis vitae*) (E4p73dem/G II 265). Agreement and concord express, at the level of human life, the intersubjective and relational logic that governs the motion of all bodies (Lazzeri 2025; Saar 2025; Solé 2025; Buhr 2023; Sangiacomo 2024: 24–27; Lord 2016; Yenter 2018; Cerezo Galán 2016).

While each of these relational accounts of Spinoza is important for understanding the uniqueness of Spinoza's *Vernunftreligion*, they fail to address a central existential and phenomenological question, namely *how does God or Nature relate to me in my everyday experience?* While relational accounts of Spinoza's philosophical religion provide a compelling birds-eye view of reality, such accounts tend to remain somewhat abstract and theoretical, raising issues of theoretical physics, pure mathematics and contentious theological questions. To address this gap, this paper seeks to develop the foundations of a Spinozist relational physics grounded in the notion of the *reciprocity of Nature*. For the purposes of this paper, we can define the notion as follows:

> **Spinoza's Law of the Reciprocity of Nature:** All finite things are reciprocally determined by another singular thing to exist in a certain way through the infinite, eternal and equal force [*vis*] of Nature by which each thing perseveres in existing (E1p28; E2p45s; DPP IIDef8; Ep 32)[9]

As I use the term, the reciprocity of Nature is at once a theoretical and *experiential* notion that underpins Spinoza's physics and metaphysics. Rather than advocating an intellectual contemplation of the infinite and eternal nature that relates all finite modes of Substance, my approach to Spinoza's relational philosophy emphasizes the everyday experience of immediate relationality that we encounter in Nature at every moment of existence: namely the infinite field of relationality encountered by the reciprocal force through which we move, act, think, persist, cohere and adjust to the movements and acts and thoughts, perseverance, coherence and adjustments of other bodies, at every moment. Inspired partly by a quantum approach to actions understood as wave functions within a field of interconnected forces, the reciprocity of Nature names the existential and phenomenological encounter of this indefinite field of reciprocating forces constituted by an infinite field of objects, particles, bodies, movements, migrations, ideas, and thoughts. In contrast to a purely theoretical relational metaphysics, the reciprocity of Nature is proposed as a way to make sense of how individuals in their everyday lives experience the immanent and immediate reciprocity of God or Nature.

[9] Unless otherwise noted, translations of Spinoza are taken from Benedictus Spinoza, *The Collected Works of Spinoza*, vol 1, ed. and trans. Edwin Curley (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press,) and Benedictus Spinoza, *The Collected Works of Spinoza*, vol 2, ed. and trans. Edwin Curley (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2016). Abbreviations for Spinoza's works are as follows: E = Ethics; KV = Short Treatise on God, Man and His Well-Being; DPP = Descartes' Principles of Philosophy; TP = Political Treatise; TTP = Theological-Political Treatise; Ep = Correspondence; p = proposition; s = scholium; c = corollary; App = appendix; Pos = postulates; L = lemma; def = definition; dem = demonstration; Pref = Preface. References to Gebhardt's Spinoza Opera (1925) are given as follows: "G II 98 ln 1–5" refers to Gebhardt, volume II, page 98, lines 1–5. An example of a full citation is: E3def3/G II 290 ln 10 = Ethics Part 3 definition 3, Gebhardt Page 290 line 10.

2 Mystical Atheism

Brook Ziporyn's *Experiments in Mystical Atheism* joins a host of recent commentators on Spinoza's views on God and atheism (Mason 1997; Hunter 2005; Zepke 2005; Melamed 2010; Carlisle 2021; Nadler 2026). Debates over whether Spinoza was an atheist, theist, pantheist, mystic, or covert Protestant have revolved around Spinoza's conception of God or Nature [*Deus sive Natura*]. In Ethics IV, Spinoza writes,

> The power by which singular things (and consequently, [any] man) preserve their being is the power itself of God, or Nature [*Dei*, *sive Naturae*] (by IP24C), not insofar as it is infinite, but insofar as it can be explained through the man's actual essence (by IIIP7). The man's power, therefore, insofar as it is explained through his actual essence, is part of God or Nature's [*Dei seu Naturae*] infinite power, i.e. (by IP34), of its essence.
>
> E4p4dem.

For Spinoza, God or Nature [*Deus*, *seu Natura*] is eternal and infinite and thus acts from necessity and not from some final cause or end. (E4Pref/G II 206 ln25). All finite things are rationally contained "in God" in the same way that all geometrical properties of a triangle are "contained" in any Extended triangle. The essence and properties of a finite triangle follow necessarily from the essence and infinite power of God or Nature. This conception of God as Nature has been interpreted in different ways as "mystical atheism" (Zepke 2005; Ziporyn 2024). While Ziporyn's chapter on Spinoza is not the first to describe Spinoza's thought as a "mystical atheism" (Zepke 2005), Ziporyn connects Spinoza's thought to a tradition of "atheist beatitude" running through Schelling, Hegel, Nietzsche, Bataille, Daoism and Buddhism. In this way, Ziporyn's work is a significant contribution to recent discussions of Spinoza's mysticism and its sources in in Jewish thought, Kabbalistic sources and Buddhist philosophy (Wetlesen 1977; Hubbeling 1977; Feld 1989; Goodman and Ravven 2002; Aanen 2016; Nadler 2014; Rozenberg 2024).

This paper does not aim to resolve the contentious question of whether Spinoza's religious views categorize him as atheist, pantheist or mystic in any sense.[10] Instead, the aim of this paper is to illuminate an overlooked aspect of Spinoza's "relational metaphysics" that has direct bearing on these debates – namely, what I call Spinoza's doctrine of the *reciprocity of Nature*. On the one hand, Spinoza's God is an impersonal, infinite Substance which does not "respond" to individual petitions or prayers in any meaningful sense. On the other hand, I argue that we can understand Spinoza's God as manifested through Nature's infinite reciprocity of force (*vis*) through which we are mutually determined in our every motion through the world.

Rather than understanding our individuality as simply a finite deduction of the cold, causal necessity of infinite Substance, turning to the reciprocity of Nature gives rise to an understanding of individuality that is constantly undergoing co-determination of being by the reciprocal interactions of our everyday movements, motions, affects, thoughts and actions. Indeed, for Spinoza, each individual thing has its own *leges sive natura* that by Nature accommodates to every other things *leges sive natura* to minimize contrariness. And because nothing is generated *ex nihilo* and Nature contains no vacuum (*DPP* 2P3), our finite bodily existence is necessarily co-determined by the reciprocity of force relations immanent to our environment. Spinoza's *Deus sive Natura* therefore reciprocates necessarily and immediately to our every individual movement in the world because our *leges sive natura* is an expression of the infinite power of *Deus sive Natura*.

This approach to the reciprocity of Nature contributes to and expands the literature on "mystical atheism". Rather than treating atheism as the mere denial of God's existence, recent work has emphasized alternative modes of ultimate concern, affective orientation, and existential affirmation that do not rely on theism. In this context, Spinoza appears as a paradigmatic figure: his identification of God with Nature (*Deus sive Natura*), his rejection of teleology and final causes, and his account of intellectual love of necessity together offer a vision of reality that is at once rigorously anti-theological and deeply affirmative. Ziporyn's contribution is especially significant because it resists two familiar misreadings of Spinoza. Against theological domestications, Ziporyn insists that Spinoza's God is not a personal being, a designer, or a moral legislator. Against deflationary naturalism, Ziporyn argues that Spinoza's philosophy nevertheless sustains a genuinely transformative, beatific, even "mystical" orientation toward existence. Spinoza's God, on Ziporyn's reading, is infinite, impersonal Substance whose power is expressed necessarily in infinitely many modes, and whose eternity can be grasped *sub specie aeternitatis* (Ziporyn 2024: 263–265). Beatitude arises not from hope, obedience, or divine favor, but from adequate understanding of the necessity of our essence as a manifestation of the infinite.

[10] On this topic, my position accords with that of Carlisle (2021) who declines to categorize Spinoza as atheist, pantheist, mystic, Christian, or Jewish, "not only because Spinoza's religious vision is so original that it eludes ready-made categories, but also because his work calls into question the very *concept* of religion that underlies such classifications." (Carlisle 2021: 6).

Yet precisely because Ziporyn emphasizes infinity, necessity, and impersonality, such an account invites a persistent objection. If God is nothing but infinite Substance, lacking will, intention, or purposive responsiveness to our personal petitions, then how can such a metaphysics sustain a "mystical" insight for finite individual human beings situated in the material world? In what ways does Spinoza's God *engage* us as embodied beings who experience themselves as acting, suffering, being affected, and interacting with a connected world that seems to answer their actions? How is Spinoza's God encountered by us existentially and phenomenologically as individuals? Without an immediate experience of individual reciprocity, does Spinoza's system risk collapsing into a pure abstract universalism or a cryptic and indifferent naturalism? In other words: *why* does Spinoza's God *matter to us* in our experience of the world as a place of reciprocity?

This paper argues that Spinoza's philosophy contains a resource for answering this objection that has not been sufficiently foregrounded in recent discussions of mystical atheism: the reciprocity of Nature. While Ziporyn's account rightly foregrounds infinity and the rejection of teleology, it leaves underdeveloped the way in which Spinoza's metaphysics and physics articulate a reciprocal structure of codetermination among finite modes—one that is neither purposive nor voluntaristic, yet irreducibly relational, dynamic and reciprocal. Spinoza's *Deus sive Natura* does not respond to human beings by will, providence, revelation, love, or concern; instead, every finite action, motion, and affect is necessarily met by immediate, reciprocal determinations within Nature itself. Reciprocity explains how the single, infinite substance of Nature can be impersonal without being indifferent to the experience of individual finite modes. Through the reciprocity of force (*vis*) that follows from Nature's infinite power, God as Nature is experienced in the everyday reciprocal force that meets our every movement, action, thought and idea, but in a non-theological, natural and immediate sense.

One common objection to Spinoza's system is that it fails to allow room for individuation by absorbing all finite modes into an expression of Infinite Substance. Here, we are reminded of Hegel's critique of Spinoza that the doctrine of Infinite Substance excludes the possibility of self-consciousness of individuality and subjectivity (Hegel 1892: 288–290). In the *Lectures on History of Philosophy*, Hegel presents Spinoza's infinite substance as an abstract universalism that disallows individuality, personality and particularity. By contrast, I argue that reciprocity provides the missing link between Spinoza's doctrine of Infinite Substance and the individual experiential depth associated with mysticism. In this interpretation, individuals as finite modes experience the infinite reciprocity of Nature in all its infinite variation, at every moment of interaction. Moreover, by foregrounding reciprocity of Nature within Spinoza's metaphysics, the paper aligns Spinoza's mystical atheism with contemporary efforts to articulate non-theistic modes of affirmation that retain normative and experiential force for *individuals* without reintroducing transcendent divine personality (Mason 1997; Bennett 2010; Carlisle 2021; Ziporyn 2024; Dockstader 2025).

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 reconstructs Ziporyn's interpretation of Spinoza's God as infinite, non-teleological Substance, with particular attention to the role of infinity and the rejection of purposive intellect. Section 3 develops the core argument of the paper: an account of the reciprocity of Nature, drawing on the *Ethics I-II*, *Letter 32*, and the *DPP*, including Spinoza's physical analysis of coherence and reciprocal change. Section 4 returns to the concept of mystical atheism, arguing that reciprocity strengthens Ziporyn's account by grounding beatitude in a lived awareness of embodied coherence and reciprocity rather than in contemplation of necessity alone.

3 Ziporyn on Spinoza

Brook Ziporyn's *Experiments in Mystical Atheism* places Spinoza at the conceptual center of what Ziporyn calls a tradition of "atheist mysticism." Chap. 5, "Spinoza, or Intoxicating Sobriety," is explicitly identified by Ziporyn as "the real center of gravity of the book," since Spinoza is the thinker who dismantles teleological thinking *from within* the Western metaphysical tradition rather than rejecting it from an external standpoint (Ziporyn 2024: 72, 189).[11] As noted, Ziporyn's interpretation of Spinoza focuses on the identification of God with Nature/Substance/Infinity, and thus on the implications of infinity understood not as an abstract magnitude but as immanent, eternal, and fully expressive of itself in finite modes. On this reading, Spinoza's philosophy does not eliminate God but radically transforms the meaning of divinity by stripping it of purpose, will, and transcendence. God is immanent to our singular plane of existence and we as individuals are finite expressions or "necessary determinations" of the infinite power and essence of God.[12]

Ziporyn frames Spinoza's intervention as a decisive rejection of the idea that the universe is the product of a purposive intellect. In a key passage, Ziporyn writes:

> The physical universe is not created for a purpose, nor indeed is it even created as something necessarily following from the nature of a nonpurposive, infinite

[11] For a comprehensive overview of scholarly debates over teleology in Spinoza, see Del Lucchese (2020).

[12] On Spinoza's "necessitarianism", see Garrett (2018).

> mind. The material universe is produced necessarily from the nature of Extension itself—that of physical infinity, space, matter. All ideas, all conscious experience, on the other hand, *are* indeed the results of an infinite intellect: mind produces mind, matter produces matter, and these are, as we have seen, just alternate ways of designating the one infinite Substance, which is itself exclusively neither matter nor mind (Ziporyn 2024: 269–270).

This claim is central to Ziporyn's account of Spinoza's God. God is not a planning intellect, and the existence of the universe is not the execution of a design. Rather, the universe follows necessarily from the nature of Substance, which Spinoza identifies with God or Nature. Ziporyn emphasizes that this necessity must not be misunderstood as the imposition of order by a rational agent. Instead, it is the expression of infinite power. Ziporyn clarifies this point by distinguishing between traditional theological models and Spinoza's conception of causality:

> The infinite intelligence in Spinoza is an infinite and eternal mode of Thought, to be sure; but (1) it is devoid of purpose, (2) it is devoid of free will (and thus plans, designs, etc.), and (3) it is the larger whole of which our own minds are parts." (Ziporyn 2024: 270).

Here Ziporyn insists that intellect, in Spinoza's sense, is not an architect of the world. Thought and Extension are attributes through which infinite Substance expresses itself, but neither governs nor directs the other. God's "intellect" names the infinity of ideas, not a conscious planner overseeing creation.

Ziporyn reads Spinoza's doctrine of Substance as the elimination of transcendence in the strongest possible sense. Substance is "that which is in itself and is conceived through itself," and therefore cannot stand in a creator–creation relation to anything else. Ziporyn stresses that God and the universe are not two realities standing in relation, but one reality understood adequately. This is why Spinoza distinguishes between *Natura naturans* and *Natura naturata*, a distinction Ziporyn repeatedly emphasizes:

> Substance, with all its Attributes, is what Spinoza calls *Natura Naturans* ('Nature as productive'). The universe as a whole is what he calls *Natura Naturata* ('Nature as produced'), which includes all modes, both finite and infinite. The former is the immanent cause of the latter, which means the productive and the produced can never be separate." (Ziporyn 2024: 236).

The crucial term here is *immanent cause*. God does not act on the world from outside it; rather, God is the causal power *within* everything that exists. Ziporyn argues that this immanence is what allows Spinoza to maintain the full divinity of God while eliminating transcendence and divine personality.

One of Ziporyn's most sustained analyses concerns Spinoza's concept of infinity. Infinity, on this reading, is not a quantitative notion but a metaphysical one. Ziporyn explicitly equates infinity with indeterminacy: "Infinite means 'indeterminate.' But indeterminacy, correctly understood, entails infinite power to determine and be determined." (Ziporyn 2024: 207) Infinity is therefore not the absence of determination but the capacity for infinite determination. Because there is nothing outside infinite Substance, all determinations are determinations of itself. Ziporyn emphasizes that this understanding of infinity blocks any attempt to conceive God as a bounded agent or as one being among others. Spinoza's definition of eternity plays a central role here. Ziporyn quotes Spinoza's definition directly: "By eternity I mean existence itself insofar as it is conceived as necessarily following solely from the definition of an eternal thing." (Spinoza, *Ethics* E1d8; quoted in Ziporyn 2024: 237) Ziporyn draws the conclusion that to exist adequately is already to exist eternally and infinitely, insofar as existence follows from the nature of Substance. Eternity for Spinoza, under this account, is therefore conceived not as timelessness but necessary existence.

A central problem addressed by Ziporyn is how finite modes such as human beings can relate to infinite Substance. Ziporyn explicitly formulates the puzzle: "Modes can neither be identical to nor different from Substance. How can we conceive this?" (Ziporyn 2024: 237) Ziporyn's answer, following Spinoza, is that finite modes are expressions of infinity rather than parts of a whole. Spinoza's metaphysics begins from the assertion that there is only one substance, absolutely infinite, consisting of infinitely many attributes (E1p11). Finite things, by contrast, are modes—"the affections of substance, or that which is in another through which it is also conceived" (E1d5). This definition immediately blocks any interpretation of finite beings as self-subsisting entities. A mode does not exist *in itself*; it exists *in* substance and is conceived *through* substance. The challenge, however, is to articulate this dependence without collapsing finitude into an undifferentiated mass of Substance. For Ziporyn, Spinoza's solution lies in the concept of "self-modification", "manifestation" or expression (Ziporyn 2024: 243–44). Infinite Substance expresses itself under each attribute, and finite modes are determinate expressions or "manifestations" of that power under specific attributes. Substance is indivisible, but modes are infinitely divisible. Ziporyn quotes Martial Gueroult to clarify this point:

> This Substance, with regard to its nature, is complete in each mode… Hence every mode, whether small or large, envelops within itself the indivisibility of infinite Substance, which is completely bestowed upon it, while by virtue of its definition as a finite being, it must admit divisibility." (Gueroult, quoted in Ziporyn 2024: 236–237).

Infinity is thus fully present in each finite mode, not as a quantity but as indivisible power. Ziporyn stresses that this means there is no smallest unit of reality and no privileged way of dividing the world.

The major result of this analysis is that every finite mode is an expression or experience of the infinite Substance. When adequately conceived through reason, the experience of drinking tea is a finite mode of infinite Substance. When we adequately conceive this experience as the necessity of infinite Substance, we hence transform the experience from a passive affect "happening to us" to an "action" understood as an affect necessarily following from what I am. Ziporyn writes,

> For the idea of necessity, of infinity, is also part of my mind since nothing can exist or be conceived apart from the idea of infinity. Actually, the idea of infinity is always actively involved in every thought and experience I have, for it is a premise without which they are unintelligible, just as I cannot understand what "motion" is unless I already understand what "space" is…Since that thought of infinity is revealed to be innately a part of my mind, my mind is now revealed to also include this experience that this-tea-leaf-fluttering-left-13°is also a necessary consequence of my existence, of my mind, and thus *is* my own mind's activity. (Ziporyn 2024: 262–263)

Ziporyn draws out the implications of this conception of infinity for Spinoza's understanding of necessity. Necessity, on this view, is not imposed from without, nor is it the result of divine decree. It is simply what follows from what a thing is. God does not choose to act necessarily; God *is* necessity. This eliminates the familiar tension between divine freedom and determinism by dissolving the framework in which that tension arises. Freedom, for Spinoza, does not consist in the ability to choose otherwise, but in acting from the necessity of one's own nature (E1d7).

This account of freedom is central to Ziporyn's understanding of Spinozistic beatitude. Beatitude does not consist in escape from necessity, nor in reconciliation with a benevolent will. Rather, beatitude arises from adequate understanding of necessity itself. To grasp oneself as a mode of infinite Substance is to grasp one's existence as necessary expression of one's essence, and in so doing increasing one's power of acting. Ziporyn thus reads Spinoza's *amor Dei intellectualis* as a form of affirmation without transcendence: an affective orientation grounded in understanding of the necessity of my essence rather than obedience to forces external to me. Despite the strength of this interpretation, however, Ziporyn's emphasis on infinity and necessity tends to privilege a vertical, one-way metaphysical relation between finite modes and infinite Substance. Finite beings are understood primarily as expressions of infinite power, and beatitude is framed largely in terms of intellectual comprehension of necessity *sub specie aeternitatis*. Ziporyn writes that *beatitude* for Spinoza means

> to understand that whatever you are doing and whatever you have ever done is nothing but a necessary expression of your essence, which is the endeavor to continue to maintain your activity, your expression of your essence in causal effects, in as many ways and as many situations as possible. (Ziporyn 2024: 267)

While this is undoubtedly central to Spinoza's ethics, it risks leaving underdeveloped the *horizontal*, material relations among finite modes themselves—relations that constitute the lived texture and meaning of finite existence with others. While this characterization of beatitude is textually and philosophically sound, it invites the question of how finite beings *encounter* such a God in the material world. If God neither intends nor responds to my concerns, needs, petitions or prayers, if Nature simply unfolds as cold causal necessity, then in what sense can Spinoza's God be *experienced* and *encountered* in the world as something engaging and responding to our individuality?

Ziporyn's answer tends to emphasize the affective transformation in joy that accompanies adequate rational understanding of necessity. For Ziporyn, Spinoza's mystic atheism consists in the dissolution of fear and the joy of intellectual clarity. Yet this emphasis risks obscuring another dimension of Spinoza's thought: the fact that finite beings do not merely rationally contemplate our necessity, but exist within a dense web of mutual codetermination and interdependence. As individuals, we act only by being acted upon; we persist only through interaction; we think better together ("two minds are better than one"); we are continuously modified by the necessary relations we have other bodies, minds, forces, passions, actions, etc. In this way, the present paper does not reject Ziporyn's account, but seeks to supplement it. The claim is not that Ziporyn misunderstands Spinoza, but that Ziporyn's interpretation leaves implicit a crucial feature of Spinoza's metaphysics—one that becomes visible when we attend closely to Spinoza's metaphysics of Extension and physics of Motion. Spinoza's God is indeed

impersonal in a theological sense, but Nature is nevertheless imbued everywhere by reciprocal power. Every finite action is met by further determinations; every exercise of power encounters resistance, adaptation, or reinforcement. This reciprocal structure is not an accidental feature of Nature, but an expression of infinite power itself.

To bring this dimension into view, it is necessary to examine Spinoza's account of individuation, motion, and interaction—topics that come to the fore in *Ethics I-II*, *Renati des Cartes Principiorum Philosophiae*, and explicitly in *Letter 32*. These texts reveal a conception of Nature as a dynamically coherent whole, in which individuality consists not in isolation but in participation in a network of reciprocal power relations. The next section develops this insight into a systematic account of the reciprocity of Nature. By turning to Spinoza's *Ethics*, *Letter 32* and the *Renati des Cartes Principiorum Philosophiae*, we can see how reciprocity functions as the concrete, lived form of immanence. This will allow us to articulate a version of mystical atheism that is neither abstract nor anthropomorphic, but grounded in the necessary coherence and reciprocity of finite existence itself.

4 The Reciprocity of Nature

If Spinoza's God is infinite, impersonal, and non-teleological, the question remains how such a God is encountered within finite existence. Ziporyn's answer emphasizes the intellectual apprehension of necessity *sub specie aeternitatis*. Yet Spinoza's own texts suggest a further dimension, one that does not replace this contemplative standpoint but complements it: the pervasive reciprocity through which finite beings exist and act. Nature, for Spinoza, is not merely the totality of necessary relations viewed abstractly; it is the continuous activity of mutual determination among finite modes. Reciprocity names the concrete structure of this activity.

This section argues that reciprocity is not a peripheral feature of Spinoza's system, but a central mechanism through which God or Nature manifests itself to us as individuals in our experience and encounter of the world. By examining Spinoza's *Ethics I-II*, his engagement with Cartesian physics in the *Renati des Cartes Principiorum Philosophiae* (*DPP*), and his remarks to Oldenburg in *Letter 32*, we can see how Spinoza articulates a conception of Nature as a dynamically coherent whole, in which individuality consists in relational stability rather than isolation. This account allows us to understand how Nature can be impersonal without being inert, and how Spinoza's God can lack purposive responsiveness without collapsing into cold determinism or inert matter separated from our being-in-the-world.

Spinoza's early engagement with Cartesian physics came in 1663 with the publication of the *Renati des Cartes Principiorum Philosophiae* (*DPP*). Here, Spinoza provides an early physical articulation of what we can call the doctrine of the reciprocal determination of bodies. Although *DPP* is often treated as a transitional work, Spinoza can be seen as developing a systematic attempt to reconceive corporeal reality in non-teleological terms. For Spinoza, bodies are understood solely through the Attribute of Extension and its immediate infinite mod of Motion and Rest (*DPP* II, Ax.1–13). A particularly illuminating passage occurs in DPP II, Lemma 2, where Spinoza explains rarefaction and condensation of bodies as examples of how finite bodies interact with their environment. Writing about condensation of bodies, Spinoza writes,

> the parts of a body—say, a sponge—by approaching one another expel the bodies which fill the intervals between the parts, this in itself renders that body more dense, and its parts will not on that account occupy a smaller space than before (by A4). And if they should move away from one another again and their path should be filled by other bodies, rarefaction will take place, and yet they will not occupy a larger space. What we perceive clearly in a sponge with the aid of the senses, we can conceive by the intellect alone concerning all bodies, even though the intervals between their parts completely escape our senses.
>
> (DPP IIL2dem)

Spinoza insists that neither process – condensation as bodies moving closer or rarefaction as bodies moving away from one another - involves a change in the amount of space occupied by the body. Rarefaction and condensation are intelligible without supposing that bodies occupy more or less space. What changes are the *relations* among parts and between bodies. Within this context, Spinoza defines the local motion of bodies (*motus localis*) as follows: "Local motion is the transfer of one part of matter, *or* one body, from the vicinity of those bodies that touch it immediately, and are considered as resting, to the vicinity of others."[13] Drawing upon the analogy of a boat stuck in the sand, Spinoza writes,

> If body A is transferred from body B, which is at rest, the same force and action are required on the one part as on the other. This is evident from the example of a

[13] "Motus localis est translatio unius partis materiae, sive unius corporis, ex vicinià corum corporum, quae illud immediate contingunt, et tanquam quiescentia spectantur, in viciniam aliorum." (DPP IIDef8/ G I 181 ln25).

> boat which is stuck in mud or sand at the bottom of the water. To free it, the force exerted on the bottom will have to equal that exerted on the boat. So the force [*vis*] by which bodies must be moved is expended equally on the body which is moved and on the one at rest. The transfer is, in fact, reciprocal (*Translatio vero est reciproca*); for if the boat is separated from the sand, the sand is also separated from the boat.
>
> DPP IIDef8(4).

Here, Spinoza makes clear that the force (*vis*) by which bodies are moved is exerted equally (*aeque…impenditur*) on the body moved and the body at rest. (DPPIIDef8p4).[14]

The sponge and boat examples illuminate Spinoza's conception of the reciprocity of Nature. First, these passages from the DPP show that changes among bodies are inherently reciprocal. When a body condenses, it changes only in relation to other force relations of other bodies; when it rarefies, it brings into play other force relations. No finite body can change without simultaneously affecting and being affected by others. Crucially for Spinoza, this change in a thing's determination of being occurs through the eternal and infinite force of Nature (*vis*). I In the *Ethics*, Spinoza often equates this force of Nature with the infinite power (*potentia*) of Nature. In Ethics II, Spinoza, speaking of the existence of finite things, writes,

> By existence here I do not understand duration, i.e., existence insofar as it is conceived abstractly, and as a certain species of quantity. For I am speaking of the very nature of existence, which is attributed to singular things because infinitely many things follow from the eternal necessity of God's nature in infinitely many modes (see IP16). I am speaking, I say, of the very existence of singular things insofar as they are in God. For even if each one is determined by another singular thing to exist in a certain way, still the force [*vis*] by which each one perseveres in existing follows from the eternal necessity of God's nature.
>
> E2p45s/G II 127.

Here, Spinoza references the eternal necessity of Nature's force (*vis*) by which all finite things persevere in their existence (*conatus*).[15] Moreover, the passages from the DPP demonstrate that this physical explanation does not require teleological, goal-driven purpose. The sponge does not condense *in order to* expel water particles; expulsion of water particles follows necessarily from the indefinite nature of Extension in every determination of a body entails a correlative determination of another body ad infinitum, since there is no vacuum in Nature. Third, it illustrates how coherence is maintained through interaction. A finite body persists as long as a certain relational structure is preserved, even as its internal and external relations shift. The sponge example thus provides a concrete model of Nature as active, non-teleological reciprocity. Nature reciprocates change with change, not because it intends to do so, but because reciprocal interaction through the infinite and eternal force of Nature (*vis*) is the only way finite bodies exist within an extended, infinite field.

Spinoza's account of the reciprocity of Nature also underpins his account of coherence (*cohaerentiam*) in *Letter 32* written in 1665 to Oldenburg. [16] In this letter, Spinoza connects his account of metaphysical individuation of bodies to a "mereological" reading of the *leges sive natura* of all things as parts within the whole of Nature.[17] As Curley notes, by1665 Spinoza had already produced a substantial manuscript of the *Ethics*, which was not published until after Spinoza's death in 1677.[18] By 1665, then, Spinoza's metaphysical views on motion, extension and coherence had advanced substantively. Responding to a question about how parts of Nature cohere (*cohaerentiam*) with the whole order of Nature, Spinoza writes,

> Now all the bodies in Nature can and should be conceived in the same way as we have here conceived the blood; for all bodies are surrounded by others and are reciprocally determined to exist and to act in a fixed and determinate way, the same ratio of motion to rest being preserved in them taken all together, that is, in the universe as a whole. Hence it follows that every body, insofar as it exists as modified in a definite way, must be considered as a part of the whole universe, and as agreeing with the whole and cohering with the other parts. Now since the nature of the universe, unlike the nature of the blood, is not limited, but is absolutely

[14] "Quapropter vis, quá corpora moveri debent, aeque corpori moto, atque quiescenti, impenditur." (G I 182 ln30).

[15] Spinoza also refers to the force (*vis*) of Nature when speaking of laws of gravity (*vim gravitatis*). See Letter 46 (Ep 46) Here, Spinoza writes that the force of gravity "communicates" (*communicabit*) motion throughout the water in a tube in a continuous way, which is what generates pressure.

[16] All translations from Letter 32 are taken from Shirley's translation. See Spinoza 2002: 848–851.

[17] I share this "mereological" reading with Sangiacomo (2019).

[18] See Curley (1985), xiii.

> infinite, its parts are controlled by the nature of this infinite potency in infinite ways, and are compelled to undergo infinite variations. However, I conceive that in respect to substance each individual part has a more intimate union with its whole. For, as I endeavoured to show in my first letter written some time ago when I was living at Rijnsburg, since it is of the nature of substance to be infinite, it follows that each part pertains to the nature of corporeal substance, and can neither be nor be conceived without it.
>
> (Ep32/G V 172) [19]

In this passage, Spinoza reiterates the doctrine that all bodies are circumscribed by others (*omnia enim corpora ab aliis circumcinguntur*) and are reciprocally determined [*ab invicem*] to exist and operate according to a certain and determinate *ratio* (*omnia enim corpora ab aliis circumcinguntur*, *et ab invicem determinantur*, *ad existendum*, *et operandum certa*, *ac determinata ratione*). (G IV 172).[20] And since all bodies are part of the infinite power of nature, each body is forced (*coguntur*) to undergo infinite variations and its parts are modified in infinite ways. Later in the *Letter*, Spinoza will repeat his claim from the *Ethics* that the human body and the human mind are also a part of Nature, whose infinite variations of their parts are also derived from the infinite power of Nature. For Spinoza, therefore, all finite things are *reciprocally* determined to exist.

Spinoza then makes an important distinction between two distinct ratios of motion (*ratione motus*) that complex bodies may have in their striving to preserve themselves: (a) a holistic *ratio* of motion that obtains as a "whole" (*rationem totius*) and (b) the internal ratios that obtain as a part of some larger system (*rationem partis*) (G IV 172). First, a complex individual body for Spinoza has a "holistic" ratio of motion to the extent that all its parts retain the same proportion of motion and rest to one another (*ratione totius*).[21]

This "ratio of the whole" is distinguished from the internal ratios of motion that hold of bodily systems like the blood, which are a *ratio* of a part (*rationem partis*) (G IV 172) Spinoza writes,

> For if we should feign that there are no causes outside the blood which would communicate new motions to the blood, and no space outside the blood, nor any other bodies to which the particles of blood could transfer their motion, it is certain that the blood would always remain in the same state, and its particles would undergo no variations other than those which can be conceived from the given relation of the motion of the blood to the lymph, chyle, etc. Thus the blood would always have to be considered as a whole and not as a part. But because there are a great many other causes which regulate the laws of the nature of the blood in a definite way, and which in turn are regulated by the blood, the result is that other motions and other variations arise in [A: the particles of] the blood which follow not simply from the relation of the motion of its parts to one another, but from the relation of the motion of the blood [A: as a whole] and of its external causes to one another. In this way the blood has the nature of a part [*ratione partis*] and not of a whole [*rationem totius*].
>
> Ep32/G V 172.

As we learn in the same Letter, the *rationem partis* that governs the blood coheres with the Human body in the same way that the Human body coheres (*cohaerentiam*) according to the *ratione totius* of its environment in Nature. Since the human body is a part of Nature in the same way that the blood circulatory system is part of the human body, it follows that the Human body coheres with the universe in the same way the circulatory system coheres with the Human body. Spinoza connects this reciprocal preservation of *ratios* to the infinity of Nature:

> Since the nature of the universe, unlike the nature of the blood, is not limited, but is absolutely infinite, its parts are controlled by the nature of this infinite potency in infinite ways, and are compelled to undergo infinite variations. (Ep32/G V 172)

Because Nature is infinite, there is no final boundary at which reciprocal determination ceases. Every finite interaction – including that between the Human body and its environment in Nature - is embedded within an indefinitely extending network of further reciprocal interactions and ratios of preservation. The infinite power (*potentia*) of

[19] This translation of *Letter* 32 is taken from Shirley. See Spinoza 2002: 848–851.

[20] Shirley translates the Latin phrase *ab invicem determinantur* as "reciprocally determined"; literally, the phrase should be rendered "determined from one another". However, I take this as a biconditional relation: A's determination occurs IFF (if and only if) B's determination occurs, and B's determination occurs IFF A's determination occurs. Given this biconditional relation Spinoza seems to be arguing for, Shirley's translation of "reciprocally determined" nicely captures the logical thrust of Spinoza's meaning here.

[21] As we learn in the *Ethics*, Desire does not affect the whole body equally, and is therefore said to have a *ratio* of a part (*rationem partis*). The affect of Cheerfulness, however, appears to manifest in the body as a *rationem totius*, since it preserves the same proportion of motion throughout the whole body (E4p42). Cheerfulness is said to be "chiefly related to the body" along with Pleasure, Pain, and Melancholy, (E3DefAffIII).

Nature is expressed precisely in this inexhaustible capacity for coherence, *ratio* and mutual determination.

This distinction between the *ratione totius* and *ratione partis* leads Spinoza to an important conclusion. For Spinoza, each body has its own *leges sive natura*, that is the "laws or nature" of a particular thing (Ep32). Spinoza writes, "By coherence of parts I mean simply this, that the laws or nature [*leges sive natura*] of one part adapts itself (*accomodat*) to the laws or nature of another part in such wise that there is the least possible opposition between them" (Ep32/G IV 172). Coherence, on Spinoza's view, is a function of the reciprocal accommodation of the *leges sive natura* of all things with another so that contrariness is minimized. According to Spinoza, the *leges sive natura* of a particular thing accommodates itself to the *leges sive natura* of other finite things such that contrariness between them is minimized (*minime sibi contrarientur*).[22] Spinoza's definition of "coherence" can therefore be described as the reciprocal accommodation of the *leges sive natura* of all things with one another by adjustment of *ratios* of motion to minimize contrariness. Coherence, therefore, occurs through the reciprocal determination of all things – that is, through the reciprocity of Nature.

Thus for Spinoza, we have two distinct features of finite bodies: (1) the bidirectionality of force (*vis*) that obtains *between* all finite modes in a reciprocal relationship, and (2) the reciprocal *determination* of each finite mode through the accommodation of the *leges sive natura* of all things. These features together imply that finite bodies and cannot be understood without their necessary relations with others. If there exists a bidirectionality of force between all finite modes, then any motion must be conceived through its relation with other bodies. If coherence is the mutual accommodation of the *leges sive natura* of all things with one another so that contrariness is minimized, then coherence necessarily implies that the determination of things *themselves* (and their *leges sive natura*) must be conceived only through mutual interaction with other finite bodies (and their *leges sive natura*). Indeed, responding to questions about part–whole relations, Spinoza insists that finite bodies cannot be understood in isolation, but only through their relations to others:

> Now all the bodies in Nature can and should be conceived in the same way as we have here conceived the blood; for all bodies are surrounded by others and are reciprocally determined to exist and to act in a fixed and determinate way, the same ratio of motion to rest being preserved in them taken all together, that is, in the universe as a whole. Hence it follows that every body, insofar as it exists as modified in a definite way, must be considered as a part of the whole universe, and as agreeing with the whole and cohering with the other parts. Now since the nature of the universe, unlike the nature of the blood, is not limited, but is absolutely infinite, its parts are controlled by the nature of this infinite potency in infinite ways, and are compelled to undergo infinite variations. However, I conceive that in respect to substance each individual part has a more intimate union with its whole. For, as I endeavoured to show in my first letter written some time ago when I was living at Rijnsburg, since it is of the nature of substance to be infinite, it follows that each part pertains to the nature of corporeal substance, and can neither be nor be conceived without it.
>
> (Spinoza 2002: 849)

Several features of this *Letter* are philosophically decisive for understanding the reciprocity of Nature. First, Spinoza asserts that reciprocal determination of bodies from another [*ad invicem*] concerns both *existence* and *action*. Bodies do not merely interact after they exist; their determination *as* finite bodies only occurs *through* interaction.[23] Second, individuality is defined not by substance or essence, but by the preservation of both external and internal ratios of motion and rest. A human body, for example, has a "holistic" ratio of motion to its external environment (*ratione totius*), alongside the various "internal" ratios of bodily parts (*ratione partis*). Third, the "holistic" ratio of the entire body to its environment is not local but global: it is preserved "taken all together," that is, within the universe as a whole. Since the human body is a part of Nature in the same way that the blood circulatory system is part of the human body, it follows that the Human body coheres with the universe in the same way the circulatory system coheres with the Human body. Spinoza connects this reciprocal preservation of *ratios* to the infinity of Nature:

> Since the nature of the universe, unlike the nature of the blood, is not limited, but is absolutely infinite, its parts are controlled by the nature of this infinite potency in infinite ways, and are compelled to undergo infinite variations" (Spinoza 2002: 849).

Because Nature is infinite, there is no final boundary at which reciprocal determination ceases. Every finite interaction – including that between the Human body and its

[22] "Per partium igitur cohaerentiam nihil aliud intelligo, quam quod leges, sive natura unius partis ita sese accommodant legibus, sive naturae alterius, ut quam minime sibi contrarientur." (G IV 172).

[23] Once again, I take Shirley's translation of *ab invicem determinantur* as "reciprocally determined" as an accurate description of Spinoza's account of co-determination of finite modes.

environment in Nature - is embedded within an indefinitely extending network of further reciprocal interactions and ratios of preservation. The infinite power (*potentia*) of Nature is expressed precisely in this inexhaustible capacity for coherence, *ratio* and mutual determination.

Meantime in the *Ethics*, Spinoza was developing these insights about motion, coherence and reciprocal determination of bodies into a formalized account of how finite modes interact under the aspect of Extension and its immediate infinite mode of Motion. In E1p28, Spinoza formally articulates a principle of reciprocal determination as follows:

> Every singular thing, or any thing which is finite and has a determinate existence, can neither exist nor be determined to produce an effect unless it is determined to exist and produce an effect by another cause, which is also finite and has a determinate existence; and again, this cause can neither exist nor be determined to produce an effect unless it is determined to exist and produce an effect, which is also finite and has a determinate existence, and so on, to infinity.
>
> (E1p28)

When viewed under a relational metaphysical perspective, E1p28 can be read as Spinoza's articulation of a formal principle of the reciprocal determination of bodies. Indeed, as Lord has argued, Spinoza's *Ethics* unveils a thoroughly relational account of finite modes, wherein individuals are constituted by the *ratio* of interaction between oneself and other finite bodies and minds (Lord 2018: 61). For Lord, *ratio* for Spinoza means a reason for action, a relation to oneself and other finite modes, and a unique proportion of motion of rest. (Lord 2018: 61). Under this view, individuation occurs through the unique *ratio* established between oneself (including one's composite parts) and all other finite bodies and minds in one's environment. Lord summarizes this picture as follows,

> We are constantly in relation to the other people and things that constitute our world and that we encounter in experience….A finite body and a finite mind exist, act, and think by virtue of their relations with other finite bodies and minds. The more relations a body enters into, the more ideas its mind – which enters into relations with the ideas of those things – is capable of perceiving. The highly composite and affective human body has a high degree of relatability, both internally, in terms of the interrelation of its constituent parts, and externally, in terms of its relations to other things. As our bodies are constantly exchanging affects with other bodies, and our minds are constantly exchanging ideas with other minds, we are constituted by these relations.
>
> (Lord 2018: 61)

For Lord, the holistic constitution of my individuality amounts to a co-determination of finitude through the reciprocal force relations that define my local environment.

It is in the Physical Interlude of *Ethics* II (E2L1–E2L7) where Spinoza develops the doctrine of reciprocal determination of finite modes by offering a general account of bodily individuation grounded in ratios of motion and rest. Spinoza's account of finite bodies is as follows: all bodies are either in motion or at rest (E2A1'), and all bodies are alike in substance and distinguished from one another only by reason of motion and rest (E2L1). All bodies agree in that they involve the same Attribute of Extension and that they are have motion and rest (E2L2). Finally, all bodies are determined to motion or rest by another body, which has been determined to motion and rest by another, and so on, ad infinitum (E2L3). As a result, no finite body be said to be determined without the reciprocal determination of another body, and so on *ad infinitum* (E2L3). With this, Spinoza defines an individual composite body not by its material components, but by a certain "ratio of motion and rest" that is preserved through motion in its environment (E2L5; E2L6; E2L7). An individual body is defined not by its material constituents, but by a stable pattern of relations that can be preserved through continual change (E2L3). This conception of individuation undermines any attempt to understand finite beings as self-contained substances. A body's individual identity is not secured by an intrinsic essence, but by the coherence of its relations with the forces of motion-rest presented by other bodies. When those force relations change beyond a certain threshold, the individual ceases to exist as that individual. Death, Spinoza writes, is not the annihilation of substance, but the dissolution of a relational equilibrium of motion and rest with one's environment caused by external bodies (*KV* 2Pref14/G I 52 ln35). For Spinoza, we are individuated as finite beings through a relationship of equilibrium of forces between ourselves and our environment.

This leads Spinoza in E2L7s to a major insight into the analysis of the individual human body. When we conceive of an individual human body, that Individual is itself composed of a number of other bodies (i.e. blood, bones, tissue) that each have their own principles of motion and rest but that, together, do not change the nature and form of the holistic Individual. From this, Spinoza concludes, "And if we proceed in this way to infinity, we shall easily conceive that the whole of nature is one Individual, whose parts, i.e. all bodies, vary in infinite ways, without any change of the

whole Individual." (E2L7dem). In the *Postulates*, Spinoza clarifies that the human body is composed of many individual "bodies" of different natures (E2Pos1), that the human body and its composite bodies are affected by external bodies in very many ways (E2PosIII), and that the human body, to be preserved, requires a great many other bodies by which it must be continually regenerated (E2PosIV). Finally, Spinoza writes that the human body can move and dispose external bodies in a great many ways (E2PosVI). Because the extension of bodies is immanent to all Nature, there is no external cause that terminates the chain.

This account of reciprocal determination of bodies reinforces the centrality of reciprocity in Spinoza's conception of *Deus sive Natura.* Bodies are individuated through interaction, persist through coherence, and perish when their relational patterns of motion and rest are disrupted beyond repair. There is no underlying substance that preserves identity independently of relations, since all bodies share in Substance. Individuation is dynamic and relational through and through. The concept of reciprocity allows us to clarify a crucial distinction. Spinoza's Nature is not providential. It does not itself aim at the good of individuals, reward virtue, or punish vice. There is no divine concern or moral oversight. Yet it would be a mistake to infer that Nature does not reciprocate or is not present "with us" at every moment, in every movement, action, thought and idea. Nature is reciprocal in a strictly immanent and immediate sense: every motion, affect and action is met by necessary determinations and interactions – like a sponge being squeezed - according to the laws and infinite power of Nature.

This conception of immediate, infinite reciprocity, I contend, is vital for understanding a Spinozistic mystical atheism. Traditional theism often associates divine reality with God's providential responsiveness—listening, answering, caring according to God's transcendent purpose and will. Spinoza rejects this model entirely. But Spinoza's relational metaphysics does not replace the transcendent God with a cold determinism or the unexplained distance of Nature's vacuum and vastness. As Spinoza writes in Descartes' *Principes of Philosophy*, the idea of a vacuum in Nature is itself a contradiction (DPP2P3). Instead, Spinoza replaces God's providential or teleological responsiveness "from on high" with an omnipresent and immediate reciprocity of force (*vis*) that is found *every-where* in every moment in every motion. Nature does not listen per se, but it always *reciprocates*; it does not care, but it never fails to act "with us" in our immediate living situation. To exist *in* God or Nature is not merely to be a passive expression or cold deduction of infinite Substance, but to participate in a potentially infinite field of reciprocal encounters with Nature. In this way, the experience of acting, encountering resistance, adapting, and persisting is itself an encounter with God or Nature in its infinite power and the indefinite field of Extension.

5 Conclusion: Mystical Atheism Reconsidered

The preceding analysis allows us to return to the concept of mystical atheism with greater precision. Ziporyn's central insight—that Spinoza offers a form of atheism capable of sustaining a genuinely affirmative and rational orientation toward reality—remains compelling. Yet such an account of mystical atheism leaves open the question of how the individual "mystic atheist" encounters the world as something engaging and *reciprocal* for individuals. Ziporyn emphasizes that Spinozistic beatitude arises from understanding the necessity of all things and relinquishing the illusion of contingency and divine purpose (Ziporyn 2024: 263–265). This emphasis aligns closely with Spinoza's own claims in *Ethics* V, where the highest form of knowledge (*scientia intuitiva*) consists in grasping things *sub specie aeternitatis*. From this standpoint, the mind comes to love God or Nature intellectually (*amor Dei intellectualis*).

However, if mystical atheism is understood exclusively in the intellectual, contemplation of things *sub specie aeternitatis*, it risks appearing detached from the interconnected material conditions of our everyday, finite and embodied life. The account of reciprocity developed in this paper shows how Spinoza can reject teleology, divine personality and transcendent purpose while nevertheless sustaining an account of Nature as radically reciprocal to the Individual. For Spinoza, God or Nature does not reciprocate by arbitrary will, concern, decree or revelation; instead, Nature reciprocates necessarily and immanently at every moment through an infinite and equal force *through which* our own self is mutually determined at every encounter. Every action is met at once by counter-actions, perturbations, adaptations, resistances and further determinations that go on *ad infinitum.*

Indeed, in recent decades, scientific research across the cognitive and neurosciences has converged on the view that reciprocity is a fundamental organizing principle of both brain function and embodied experience. As Hari et al. (2015) observe, the traditional "spectator" model of passive observation has largely been rejected in favor of a contemporary "second-person" and interaction-based neuroscience, which demonstrates that social cognition is intrinsically reciprocal, arising through real-time, dynamic coupling between agents rather than isolated internal processing (Schilbach et al. 2013; Redcay and Schilbach 2019). Studies further show that eye-to-eye engagement produces emergent, co-constituted neural states that cannot be reduced

to either individual alone, but instead reflect structured patterns of mutual influence and information exchange (Lee et al. 2025). At the sensory level, reciprocity likewise governs perception, whereby the auditory and visual systems continuously modulate and are modulated by one another (Tang et al. 2026). Even basic physiological processes exhibit reciprocal structuring, such as the inverse relation between light intensity and sensory response (Gillary 1974; Williams et al. 1999), or the coordinated coupling of visual accommodation and convergence in perception (Fincham and Walton 1957). Taken together, these findings suggest that reciprocity is not an emergent or secondary feature of cognition, but a pervasive and multi-level principle through which interaction, perception, and coordinated activity are constituted across biological systems.

In this way, contemporary scientific literature supports the Spinozist thesis advanced here that Nature's infinite succession of reciprocity does not depend on a transcendent God who responds to our petitions. Instead, Nature's reciprocity for Spinoza is simply the determined, necessary way finite existence unfolds as the expression of the infinite and reciprocal power of Nature. From this perspective, a relational mystical atheism grounded in the reciprocal power of Nature is neither a purely intellectual stance nor a covert religiosity. It is an experience itself inseparable from the powers of a multitude of others (i.e. bodies, minds, thoughts, ideas, structures, forces, etc.). To live well as a relational mystic atheist is then to understand the conditions under which one's embedded relations with other finite modes enhance rather than diminish one's power, and to align oneself with those relations as far as possible. And since the greatest good is common to all and can be equally enjoyed by all (E4p36), and virtuous persons desires for others what they desire for themselves (E4p37), a Spinozist mystic atheism can be understood as a shared pursuit of what enhances *everyone's* power – namely joining in agreement with others in common *ratios* of living and (*rationem communis vitae*) (E4p73dem/G II 265).

To be sure, Spinoza clarifies that reciprocity as such can take the form of reciprocal Hate (E3p40s) or reciprocal Love. (E3p41s). If guided by affects of passion, (i.e. Envy, Hate, Ambition etc.), reciprocity may take the form of striving to force others to "reciprocally" Love what we Love and Hate what we Hate, or desiring "reciprocally" the riches that the wealthy possess. These forms of reciprocity can be understood as pathologies of reciprocity grounded in the error of thinking that Nature was made *for us and only us to possess.* But the notion that Nature was "made for us to possess" is a fundamental error of reason. Not only is there no transcendent God who "made" Nature "for us", but the infinite substance and power of Nature is not something that *can* be "possessed" in any meaningful proprietary sense. Thus, the fundamental error at the bottom of all pathologies of reciprocity (Hate, Envy, Ambition) is the error in thinking that Nature was intentionally made for us as individuals to *possess.*

If guided by *reason*, however, reciprocity will take the form of common *ratios* of living that cohere with others and thereby increase everyone's power involved. When guided by reason, reciprocity takes the form coherence with others through sharing common *ratios* of living. This is why for Spinoza, Joy arises when encounters enhance coherence in our reciprocal force relations; sadness arises when they disrupt it (E3p11s). Ethics, on this view, is inseparable from an ontology of common ratio and the mutual determination of being. To truly experience through reason the reciprocal power of one's own determination is to live reciprocity in the form of a struggle for *coherence* with others as parts of the whole of Nature. In my reading of Spinoza, reciprocity in a political community entails identifying and agreeing with others on common *ratios* of living (*rationem communis vitae*) (E4p73dem/G II 265).

This account allows us to clarify what is distinctive about Spinoza's relational metaphysical system in relation to God or Nature (*Deus sive Natura*). It is not exactly the denial of God's existence, but neither is it merely the intellectual affirmation of causal necessity. Spinoza's system provides an immediate, *existential* awareness of the inseparability of oneself from the infinite succession of reciprocal encounters of Nature that manifests at every moment and in every action. In this light, Spinoza's relational metaphysics consists not in the contemplation of the infinite as such, but in experiencing the omnipresent reciprocity *through which* we persist, breathe, adapt, resist and strive to cohere in the world. Nature does not "listen", command, or console. But Nature always reciprocates, *immediately*, whether our sensations are presently attuned to it or not. In this sense, Spinoza's philosophy offers not only a critique of theism, but a constructive vision of what it means to affirm the reciprocity of God/Nature as individuals immersed in infinite reciprocity who strive for coherence with the whole of Nature.

Whether this account of reciprocity categorizes Spinoza as a mystical atheist, pantheist or mystic is, to my mind, far less important than appreciating the uniqueness of Spinoza's account as it stands.[24] In any case, the account of Spinoza's doctrine of reciprocity developed here contributes to an understanding of mystical atheism that denies teleology and divine transcendence while affirming the mystical experience of Nature's infinite succession of reciprocal interactions in our everyday lives. As I've argued, by tuning into the common *ratios* immanent to the everyday, immediate reciprocity of Nature, Spinoza tells us in Ethics V that

[24] Carlisle's interpretation of Spinoza's *Ethics* (2021) and Mason's study of Spinoza (1997) are excellent examples of this approach.

> we feel and know by experience that we are eternal. For the Mind feels those things that it conceives in understanding no less than those it has in the memory. For the eyes of the mind, by which it sees and observes things, are the demonstrations themselves. (E5p23s)

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